

BRITISH PARLIAMENTARY DEBATE CONSIDERED AS *PRAXIS* FOR ARGUMENTATION

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It's 1915, and Professor Howard Woodward is in a moment of pedagogical crisis. His students have approached him wanting to debate that socialism might be beneficial for the United States. In the early 20th century, competitive debating was not tournament-focused. Debates before the public were judged by agreed-upon men of a particular *ethos*, such as community leaders, lawyers, and the like, who then shared their decision with the audience. Professor Woodward knew no fair judges could be obtained for such a topic. Since the students were motivated, and good research could be found for both sides, Woodward (1915) decided to eliminate judges from his debates that year. His reasoning was twofold. First, his students, "felt it [the topic] would be an exceedingly profitable one to study and because they were sure it would be an interesting one to discuss" (p. 229). Second, the topic was anchored to contemporary public discussion, something Woodward thought was often missing from debates:

The selection of the question was approached in the belief that it should be of such importance that one actually hears it discussed on the street and by all sorts of people, even though men may generally be very partisan and prejudiced. . . I believe questions should be so selected, and more generally would be, if there were no judges' votes always to

engage the weather eye. (p. 229)

Woodward's choice in practice indicates an implicit theory of debating. His concern for good debate consists of questions about the intrinsic and extrinsic purpose of debate. Such a dual-consideration invokes *praxis*, the ancient concept of practice and theory informing one another, creating what could not be made by either alone.

2015 has much in common with 1915. When looking at debate formats, we are in a Woodwardian position. The rise of British Parliamentary (BP) debating in the United States offers an opportunity to explore alternative debate practices. This essay argues that BP debating can be theorized as *praxis*. Hans Georg Gadamer (1975) believed *praxis* to have a strong valence with prudence - the ability to make judgments in human affairs - the realm of uncertainty. BP has the potential to interrogate the Woodward question: Can we have a conception of debating where the value derives from more than the competition?

If ever someone desired to write the comprehensive history of the practice of collegiate debating in America, it would be a history of attempts to theorize it. From very early on, teachers of debating primarily theorized through their actions - like Professor Woodward. The arrival and increasing popularity of British Parliamentary debate since the early 2000s in the United States is a ripe opportunity for reconsideration of the purpose of competitive debate. Yet, instead of general theory questions, we appear mired in a contest of format superiority. The questions begged in these conversations are, ironically, the questions that unify debate practice the most: What makes a good debate? What makes a good speech? How do we know when something is proven? What counts as argument?

Such questions, also at the heart of argumentation scholarship, are constitutive of the drive to theorize. Considered as *praxis*, British Parliamentary debating has incredible theoretical value for debating on the whole because it incorporates the return to these questions in each instance of a round. In a sense, BP debate is the “unsettling” practice of debating, a format where uncertainty is practiced.

Gadamerian *Praxis* and BP Debate

Concerns over judging are the metonymy in which debate is understood. Arguments over appropriate judging stemmed from the formation of debating leagues in colleges in the mid-19th century and continue today. This metonymy can be quite extensive, and is not exclusive to the practice of competitive debating. William Keith (2007) argued that disputes over judging serve as the space where larger issues of purpose of the field of speech communication play out. BP stokes these questions, underscoring the uncertainty involved at the heart of most decisions made in response to persuasive discourse.

Even those unfamiliar with British Parliamentary debating are aware that BP tends to celebrate itself as a place where reasonable argumentation to reasonable audiences is a rule of the game. BP wants to eschew technical argumentation in favor of broader rhetorical appeals, forbidding expert or exclusionary information in arguments. BP’s conception of the audience is closest to Chaim Perelman and Lucie Olbrechts-Tyteca’s (1969) conception of the universal audience, “that for each speaker at each moment, there exists an audience transcending all others, which cannot easily be forced within the bounds of a particular audience” (30). The universal audience is that audience imagined by the speaker to be all reasonable persons within the culture

or society the speaker is addressing, “They [arguers] think all who understand the reasons they give will have to accept their conclusions” (p. 31). Therefore, the particular knowledge base or specialization of the individual serving as judge should not be deferred to, instead, presence is given to the role the judge plays as a member of the culturally and socially broader universal audience.

Judging instructions from World Championships underscore this view, as they continually remind the judges that they are an embodiment of a broader audience. The Berlin Worlds (2013) judging instructions stated, “Judges assess which team did the best job at persuading them that the motion ought to be affirmed or rejected. They do this as the ‘ordinary intelligent voter’ and consider the strength of the arguments that each team presents. While doing so, judges apply a very small set of technical rules.” Chennai Worlds (2014) instructed,

Judges assess which team did the best job at persuading them that the motion, in the context in which it was discussed during the round, ought to be affirmed or rejected. Judges do this as an ‘informed global citizen’ and consider the strength of the arguments that each team presented.

The WUDC Debating and Judging Manual (2015) stated, “Judges should avoid presuming a geographic, cultural, national, ethnic or other background when assessing arguments” (p. 13). From this small sample, one can see the judge neither serves as himself or herself, nor as a technical expert, but as someone trying to make a good decision based on what he or she heard. Such a position means that decisions in debates rely on *uncertainty* as the position of the judge, as opposed to *mastery* which is assumed in most U.S. formats. This

level of uncertainty is at the root of BP's *praxis*. Coming from a global culture that valorizes certainty and data-driven decision making, such a focus can be unsettling to say the least. This is where the value of *praxis* becomes clear as not all life decisions can be made in the same way.

Hans-Georg Gadamer (1975), believed that people have forgotten how to be prudent. The term he used for prudence – taking into account the situation - is *praxis*. This term has been defined in many ways, notably by pedagogical theorists, as reflective action of one type or another. Bell hooks (1994) defined it as “action and reflection upon the world in order to change it” (p. 14). Her definition stems from work by Paulo Friere and Tich Nhat Hahn, and possibly others who theorized the moment of teaching as a creative and active one as opposed to the ingesting of the rules of a static world. *Praxis* is the interweaving of theory and practice in order to identify and address ideologies for the purpose of developing action. Engaging in *praxis* is engaging a living, fluid system rather than a static, certainty-driven procedure.

Gadamer envisioned *praxis* as an antidote to the global application of mathematical reasoning to all human affairs - the modern desire to be data-driven:

The importance of method consists in the fact that by its own definition it investigates only by elaborating questions which are accessible for mathematical abstraction and measurement or its equivalents. If everyone would share this insight of any authentic scientist, there would be no room for the widespread idolatry that presumes that science alone should organize our life and culture. (p. 310)

This rush to confuse the scientific approach to epistemology with certainty and accuracy has made

understanding lopsided, preferring to reduce questions of a more humanist nature to fit the categories of science. Gadamer explained how this scientific over-determinism confused the understanding of *praxis*:

The concept of 'praxis' which was developed in the last two centuries is an awful deformation of what practice really is. In all the debates of the last century practice was understood as application of science to technical tasks. That is a very inadequate notion. It degrades practical reason to technical control. In fact, reason as guiding our practical behavior is much more than technical control. Praxis is not restricted to the special area of technical craftsmanship. It is a universal form of human life which embraces, yet goes beyond, the technical choice of the best means for a pre-given end. (p. 312)

Praxis, for Gadamer, is the human being selecting a means of technical control, not the refinement of technical tasks to gain mastery or control. In the terms of BP debate this is unique in comparison to the practices of other formats - a certain amount of technical control is needed to enter the debate in many American formats. Even the more radical departures in style and argument content seen in recent years require an understanding of the technical rules of debating in order to find these departures persuasive. BP rewards the selection of the "right" argument in a debate - the most persuasive one to the universal audience - but at the same time attempts to avoid reduction of the debate to a set list of potential round-winning argument structures or moves the expert judge would recognize and reward for their correct placement. BP debating places the context and situation of the debate as the rubric to understand an argument's value. Arguments don't have a value outside of the particularities of their

deployment within British Parliamentary debating.

Gadamer argued that a proper understanding of *praxis* is possible if we renew Aristotle's alternative to technical control as mastery. That is we need to develop comfort with the uncertain set of conditions that human beings face when thinking:

To justify the procedure proper to this broader field, we must re-enact Aristotle's ideal of *praktike episteme*; this ideal anticipated the crises in method of the modern humanities. For Aristotle, *praktike episteme* does not share the pretense of the ideal of science, i.e., of an approach to the world that eliminates uncontrollable and unobjectifiable factors. Aristotle developed an ideal of method which corresponds to the special conditions of our practical knowledge. These special conditions involve the understanding that members of society are the only possible students of the rules and the constitutional elements of social and political life (312).

The *praktike episteme* is an approach that includes the context, situation, experience, and the messiness of positioned, human thinking. The advantage of recovering *praktike episteme* is an orientation toward human affairs beyond just technical accuracy. The result is a performed, political position that accepts the presence of the unknowable and unquantifiable in events and in subjects.

What is at stake in Gadamerian *praxis*? Gadamer believed that the re-establishment of *praktike episteme* serves as a ground for the discussion and deliberation of those things that are not only vital principles to human existence but craft human existence through rhetorical exchange:

Immediate and natural interaction in the course of daily life is no longer the unique source and the dominant mode for the elaboration of common convictions and normative ideas. That is why the alienation of the common citizen from public affairs is increasing and why the reaction against this precarious disintegrative power, i.e., against the 'establishment', is so strong. How can we learn to recover our natural reason and our moral and political prudence? In other words, how can we reintegrate the tremendous power of our technique within a well-balanced order of the society and reconstitute a living solidarity? (p. 314)

The answer is within debate conceived of as *praxis* practice. Gadamer was certain about the need to recover prudence for political, social, and moral reasons. Debating can help to recover prudence, as the practice of debating is the prudent application of argumentation to the debate situation - the judges, the topic, and the arguments of opponents. The operation of debate is a practice of prudence, or *praxis*, as what works in one debate may spectacularly fail in another. Incorporating this comfort with situational, rhetorical modes of thought and approaches is the way to help practice the integration of healthy normative conviction back into daily life.

BP debate, with its attempt at crafting a non-specialist rubric for debates and a focus on argumentation aimed at a universal audience, can be understood as Gadamerian prudence. It is valuable to prepare for competitions based on such a rubric as they engender acceptance of uncertainty. Gadamer continued:

As relevant as the application of science is in many fields of the social life, the properly 'practical'

function of prudence is a very different one. It concerns the making of responsible political and practical decisions about happiness, health, peace, freedom and other stable factors of human-being-in-nature. (p. 312)

Praktike episteme sounds very much like a reasonable approach to crafting topics for a successful debating tournament. BP, as a place to practice this *praxis*, allows people who exist in a highly technical, highly regimented system of reasoning to reflect on it through crafting rhetorical responses to complicated questions about human affairs, such as politics, economics, and cultural beliefs. The benefit here is not only a very unique approach to debating (non-reliance on pleasing the technical specialist) but also rhetorical practice within judging. Each panel must come to consensus on the decision of the debate, which requires conversation about each judge's perspective. There's no formal rubric that can be applied outside of the perspective of these others. Everyone is an interested, non-specialist listener.

This theory locates BP debate as a specific practice that is immersed in yet distinct from the argumentation that appears in daily life. BP debate seen as *praxis* for the development of *praktike episteme* provides a place for approaches that can be used indirectly in the larger world. This is only possible if BP considers itself as distinct from, yet connected to, a world where its practices apply. BP as a place for the practice and development of *praktike episteme* makes sense, Debaters and judges are regularly called upon to be familiar with controversies, positions within those controversies, foreign governments, social and cultural principles of various countries, economic theories, philosophies of justice, international sports, currency markets, and many other realms of controversy. But they are not called upon to become the technical

masters of these fields, nor determine what the right policy is in any of the controversies. The familiarity is with the rhetoric within and surrounding these domains as a universal audience would see it. The question becomes one of what is reasonable, prudent, and sense-making about these policies and claims to anyone, rather than what is ontologically true or necessary to the expert of a field. Of course there is crossover, but only so much as the universal audience will accept as sense-making. Pushing that limit - the gap between the expert and the interested person - can sometimes crumble in perplexing ways. The debater finds him or herself offering the best argument based on the best reasons yet still loses the debate. This is the generative moment of the pedagogy of *praxis*. Developing an argument that is technically persuasive yet rejected by the universal audience is the heart of not only BP's *praxis*, but the norm that what is true is not necessarily most convincing. Gadamer's prudence revolves around developing comfort with normative claims that, although uncertain, may still be true and need articulation.

The pragmatic result of this approach is a practice that is neither comfortable nor easy. The BP competitive world mirrors the pedagogy of the Zen Buddhist monastery, or the Samurai training hall - oral tradition from those with experience, followed by a continual and relentless - often times crushing - practice. Those who have some experience are looked to as resources, either explicitly asked for instruction, or imitated in competitive speeches. It is a community that looks to its own members as models. Students study about global controversy, prepare arguments, enter the fray, learn from the decision, and then continue on. Eventually, this practice of constant critical engagement cannot be contained, and the perspective is turned to things

beyond the debate topic - the university, the society, and the self. This is the transformative power of debating, and it is something that is also at the heart of a sophisticatedly oriented rhetorical education: We are all making ourselves with and from the terms spoken around us. This is meaning making. This is world making. In Gadamerian terms, it is the practice of making decisions within and for an uncertain, human world.

BP is not a zero-sum game. Degrees of argument quality are evaluated each round. There is no winner, no loser, but a spectrum of results. Each team, ranked on their performance in relation to the other teams in the room, must build arguments and critique the arguments of opponents in order to do well. Sometimes the cooperative elements between teams on the same bench become important. Judges often are other students. They require critical listening, re-articulation of points, synthesis and evaluation, as well as negotiation in order to do it well. BP is much less like an intercollegiate athletic program - one of the typical analogies reached for by American competitive debate programs - and more like a hard-science's laboratory - complex, uncertain, sometimes expensive, but required for the appreciation of theory learned in the classroom. Competitive debate can be seen as a curricular element in the development of critical thinking, politically-minded students for a world where communication is the most sought after ability. BP debate is the laboratory for the liberal arts.

The view of *praktike episteme* allows for a curricular analog to BP, broadening the scope and potential view of debating for the university. As practice in the delicate art of making decisions and advocating on issues that are unclear, rooted in humanist ideas, and without a clear rubric for decision, the analog

suggests practice. Much like a science lab, practice in doing what a scientist does increases respect and acceptance for scientific thinking. Likewise, the practice of making prudent decisions that don't fit within a clear, technical rubric is valuable for increasing respect for and acceptance of pluralist political views. It does so by increasing comfort with the practice of uttering the wrong thing - a necessary risk if one wants to win a tournament or persuade another in the world.

Gadamer's notion of *praxis* is apparent in this articulation of the workings of British Parliamentary debate. But what does the adoption of the theory of *praxis* mean for those involved? How does it change or alter the scope and vision of BP enacted by those who practice it now?

The Practice of *Praktike Episteme*

Debate exists in the daily lives of all humans. Formal engagement with disagreeing others evaluated by another takes place in many institutional and cultural venues. As such, discussions of the aspirational or teleological end of BP debate can draw from the human experiences of the participants as a justification for the rules. *Praxis* gives practitioners a way to ground the rules of a debating competition on something accessible and familiar to everyone - the disagreement necessary to human life. This does not need to take on a completely practical dimension - that is, mirroring the types of argumentation done in society as a whole. Instead, the practice can take experiential argumentative norms and reflect on them to generate normative claims about argumentation - then advise those forms to be included when debating. The result is an anchored BP practice that contains both theory and practice rooted in daily, lived human experience. This 'common-core' of assumptions about argument can be

a rich place from which to practice then reflect on what things make arguments effective.

BP as *praxis* gives it connection to contemporary argumentation theory, whose scholars are, “broadly speaking, interested in the problems involved in the *production*, *analysis*, and *evaluation* of argumentative discourse. In studying these problems, they view argumentative discourse in the light of the actual circumstances in which it takes place” (van Eemeren, et. al., 1996, p. 12). BP as *praxis* certainly has connection, particularly to judging competitive debates, with the work of these scholars. But this connection should be explored with caution. There are serious differences between BP and argumentation theory in orientation. Argumentation theory seeks to judge, account, and criticize forms of argument that are created as a response to the “bubbling-up” of controversy. In debating tournaments, no such bubbling up occurs. Topics are assigned, and positions are assigned. There is no negotiation; no choice is deliberated by the teams. Unlike law, debaters can’t refuse to take a case. Practitioners locate points of controversy or *stasis* in order to generate persuasive arguments. They are not motivated by a perceived wrong, or influenced that things must change in the world. On the contrary, debaters are motivated to come together in great numbers under assurances that disagreement will take place at particular times in particular rooms on particular days. The insights argumentation theory provides are good for what I would call “natural language” argumentation - when people are trying to persuade one another in the world. Argumentation theory deals with the anchor-point of BP - daily, lived argumentative practices, but then departs in a different direction - evaluating the quality and nature of those practices rather than trying to engage with them as

practice.

The unfortunate result of uncritical reliance on argumentation studies to evaluate or develop a theory of BP debate is one that is too thin, or results in a predictable, bland form of scholarship. Using a theory in a plug-and-play method - for example, looking to see if a speech from a WUDC final round meets the rules for critical discussion established by pragma-dialectical theory - will typically confirm the insights of the theory and not tell us very much more than how the speech meets the expectations of the theory.

There is another key difference between BP *praxis* and argumentation theory - BP is not necessarily a hermeneutic for deeper understanding of the topical issues that are engaged with during a debate. Argumentation theory and rhetorical theory both prioritize understanding as a key focus of their work. In BP, the focus of this practice is on the creation of argumentation, not the understanding of all the persuasive or argumentative aspects of a controversy. Argumentation theory examines the controversy over time, between advocates, and often the publics involved. BP as *praxis* is focused on the production of speech within the confines of a universal audience, one that is oriented toward the speaker and listener, one oriented toward reflection on the production of persuasive arguments for that general, reasonable audience. Argumentation theory is parallel, but is rarely interested in improving the production of arguments. Instead, argumentation scholars look for implicit theory of arguing or evidence made apparent through the playing-out of the controversy over time.

Dilip Gaonkar (1993) pointed out that the domination of hermeneutic, critical theories of understanding in rhetorical scholarship elides theory's

role in the creation of persuasive messages. “By and large, our critical studies are sustained by the vocabulary of classical rhetoric, a vocabulary primarily fashioned for directing performance rather than facilitating understanding” (p. 263). Such caution can be analogously applied to theorizing BP debate. When argumentation theories are applied, we find the theory quickly outstrips the artifact. Vast swaths of how tournaments come together, how debaters arrive at their arguments, and how audiences at debate competitions listen to and evaluate such arguments are left out for the most part. The entire debating experience is stripped away, and the assumption is that these debates will function on the level of persuasion in the same manner as arguments generated in public spaces, in response to policy or the suggestion of policy, and in the mix of myriad concerns about expertise and evidence that are handled very differently in BP debating. The end is unsatisfying both to argumentation scholars and debate practitioners. This can be thought of as two different interests. Argumentation theory is interested in the account of an argument in order to evaluate it as argumentation, whereas debate *praxis* would focus on the production of argumentation and the account of how that production was received. In short, argumentation theory is less interested in prudence than debating is.

BP as *praxis* anchors the practice of BP debate to a large body of experiences familiar to those who are participating, grounding argument and its judgement in a relationship to something outside of itself - human experience. Argumentation theory, seeking the intellectual account for how argumentation plays out, might not be the best body of terms to use to craft a theory of what BP debaters are doing when they craft arguments for the universal audience. In the final

section, I suggest two starting terms for that deeper theorizing of *praxis*, to give BP practitioners some terms upon which they can measure their practice of prudence.

BP: Mimetic and Aesthetic Debating Practice

The two starting terms for BP *praxis* should be the aesthetic and the mimetic. These two terms function to start and provide grounding for the necessary discussion of practice and its relationship to theory. Uncertainty in debate, brought about by the adherence to a universal audience of “reasonable people” makes BP the perfect arena for the practice of Gadamerian *praxis*. What can we say if a debating practice that we like is continually rejected by judges? What can we do if an argument that we find disconcerting is commonly voted for in competitive debates? The localization of key terms for the consideration of theory and action helps a discussion form that could address these questions.

Aesthetic concerns raise the question of what debate should feel like, look like, and sound like. This is distinct from the question of what counts as a valid or persuasive argument, but it includes those judgments within its purview. It asks the question “What does a good argument look like?” The aesthetic has taken many forms in rhetorical scholarship, but I believe Reeves and Stoneman (2014) provided a helpful guideline: “Aesthetic rhetoric is less a commitment to a set of methodological concerns or an intellectual tradition than an interest in exploring rhetoric beyond the rational and the true” (p. 137). The aesthetic aspect deals with the question of recognition as well as the question of situation. This question of what good debating looks like or should look like has powerful rhetorical purchase for *praxis*. The reason is the

anchor - people involved in the conversation around the question will draw from their own experiences in argument to contribute their view to the community. The decision is one of permission - what is allowed in and kept out - but also one of what should be included in performance. Questions such as rate of delivery, type and quality of evidence and/or proof, and nature of the grounding of argumentation (legal, social, economic, etc.) can all be discussed in relation to whether or not they maintain appropriate aesthetic quality in relation to the practice of practical knowledge.

The interpretation of *mimesis* that I find most productive for orienting theoretical approaches to BP debate is that offered by Gebauer and Wulf (1995), who argued that it is an art and a practice that maintains an interpersonal fluidity throughout:

It is an interpersonal activity, which is to say that others are always included in it; and that it makes use of a material medium and occurs in situations that can be interpreted in material terms. From this perspective no sharp line can be drawn between artistic and other, extraartistic representations. (p. 21)

Mimesis is “the product of a practice: the practice of the hands in the formation of materials, painting, or writing; of the face, the mouth, the whole body; of the collective activities of a linguistic community” (1995, p. 21). *Mimesis* is less the conception of a historical or cultural view that only permits representations of a limited reality - in this conception, *mimesis* is a collective attempt to represent activity, spurring more activity inside and outside the text. Related to this is the second question that should orient BP theory discussions. *Mimesis* is a question of degree of attachment for BP debate practitioners.

BP *praxis* considers *mimesis* the degree of similarity BP argumentation should have toward daily, lived argumentation.

Such an interpretation for BP as *praxis* would be oriented around the question “how representative of daily argumentation do we wish debate to be?” A direct comparison toward the ways or methods that are called “arguing” in daily life is called for. The answers will vary, but all will push us to consider the relationship of BP’s rhetoric to the rhetoric of arguments made in daily life. The space created, this gap between our practices and the practices outside BP, will be foundational in building the home of BP theory.

Realism is not the issue. The concern with *mimesis* is the articulation of the relationship to other forms of argumentation through practice. The question keeps practitioners active and engaged in the linguistic community of debaters, attempting to represent the reasonable person as both ideal and norm within BP practice. By comparison to real-world debates and argumentation, and forcing position on a spectrum of various activities that could be named “debating,” the mimetic question allows for vibrant, living community norms. The practices of the community require regular reflection when asked for comparison to daily modes of argumentation, stringing the discussion of practices with the theories defending them. Advancing understanding of how the reasonable person standard relates to other practices of debating - all mimetic representations of the ideal of “debate” - ensures that the definition, with its limits and potential, is always present and under consideration. Without such a teleological discussion, oriented around the aesthetic and mimetic questions I propose, BP might lose its *praxis* and risk that fate of many other debating formats: a self-referential discourse that not only does

not correspond to an outside rhetoric, but actively eschews it. To theorize is not to provide total protection against such a result, but it is better than the alternative – to actively avoid theorizing debate.

Theorizing is Inevitable

What happens to BP if we do not theorize it? Eric Barnes (2013) argued, “to maintain the integrity of BP debate, we should avoid certain theorizing about the ideals of debating” (p. 10). Barnes was concerned that in discussing of the ideals of good debating - “aspirational” goals of debate as he terms them - we risk disconnecting the judging of debates “from how any ‘real audience’ (i.e., an audience of non-debaters) would actually react to the speeches” (p. 11). Barnes wished to keep BP debate grounded in what could be called a real-world rubric, where debates are evaluated as closely as possible to how an audience would.

Barnes’s critique of teleological theorizing of what good BP should look like is quite cynical. His assumption was that “every controversial theoretical stance about a normative issue implies some kind of intuitively absurd recommendation -- the crucial point is that committing to one of these theories makes it much more likely to see these intuitively absurd recommendations as acceptable” (p. 20). He argued that theorizing the ends or point of debate is dangerous due to extremism, brought about by “the intellectual drive toward innovation and uniqueness” (p. 21). His example was the “actual job requirements” of academe, which requires publication: “to publish, an academic must be theoretically innovative - say something new.” His example was what he viewed as a problem in literary theory - “part of the reason for the explosion of outlandish theories by literature professors (covering issues far beyond literature) over the past several

decades is the desire and need people have to articulate and defend a new theoretical position" (p. 21). Barnes concluded by reminding the reader that in debating the stakes are "very low indeed" and that teleological theorizing will create "extremism antithetical to a debate format dedicated to remaining accessible to a generalist audience" (pp. 23-4). In short, theorizing about the ends of debate may very well end BP's unique and valuable contribution.

Perhaps the easiest and most obvious response to Barnes is to point out that his argument itself is teleological theorizing. Implicit (and in some places explicit) in his call for no teleological theorizing is the teleological theory that debate is best when such speculation is repressed, kept private, or disallowed entirely from the competition. The question as to what the ends of debate should be - what makes good debate - is explicitly and publicly answered by Barnes: No theorizing, except in this case.

The performative contradiction does not ruin Barnes's argument. On the contrary, it performatively enhances the need to theorize since even in a call to stop theorizing BP debate, we wind up with a theory. What happens if we take Barnes's claim seriously and stay quiet about the teleological ends of debating? The answer is that pragmatic practices necessary for the operation of tournaments will govern the ends of debating.

The promulgation of theory in literary studies, rhetoric, and other fields has to do not with a career-obligation to produce novel texts, but a desire to understand what it means to say something is "literature" or "literary." Theorizing debate teleologically has the same function - what do we mean when we call a debate "good?" For Barnes, the

“received view” which tempers argument construction within the bounds of what has been done before is the only appropriate answer. What he excludes are questions that could be productive for those practicing BP: Which publics? What audiences? What claims? What support? Also, and detrimental to his own position, what have we accepted previously in BP, and why?

Biomedical ethics, the example used by Barnes, is oversimplified. He believes a biomedical expert would favor a particular theorization over the circumstances he or she faced. Modern bioethicists perceive all options as matters of degree. Bioethics, “regards all the scientific and technological disciplines as ranged along a spectrum. . . all of them are in one or another respect both intellectual and technical, and each combines theoretical analysis and practical technique in its own distinct way” (Jonsen & Toulmin, 1988, p. 36). The best practitioners are engaged in a close relationship to a living conception of theory appropriate to the situation. The duality of theory and practice is what Gadamerian *praxis* brings to BP. The “received view” brings a poor and conceptually thin set of tools with which to work.

Furthermore, allowing the necessary rules for a competition to dominate the entire conception of the event leads to a detrimental anti-intellectualism. The result of an under-theorized debate practice harms more than just those practicing debate. This reviewer’s rejection of a panel I proposed at the National Communication Association where graduate communication students were to reflect on the connections of communication theory with their debating experiences indicates the scope of the problem:

I am not a fan of meta-critiques of debate

activities, and this panel feels like it is mostly an effort to extend a Kritik to parly [*sic*]. That will kill the activity, and it is the natural outcome of these papers. What I had hoped to read was some actual empirical work on debate. Even the “liminal space” paper could be informed by ethnographic work. But instead, we have a thin re-description of debate activities informed by various theories. I am not so anti-intellectual as to oppose such thinking, but I see the benefit of this panel to be pretty minimal.

The reviewer believes such thinking to possibly contain value, as long as it is not articulated. Only things that have certain value to the tournament - an empirical, data-driven analysis - should be presented. Without prudence, a conceptualization of how theory and practice work together, this reviewer is dismissive of anything not clearly helpful to the practice of tournament debating. We see incapacity instead of prudence when confronted with reflective theory. Without *praxis*, practitioners of debate cannot conceive of debating outside of practice alone. This is the danger of avoiding or rejecting theorization. One winds up with a discourse about rules for disconnected events that eschew a public, serving nothing but the rules of an isolated contest.

Looking to argumentation theory or Barnes’s received view of debating are the natural results of the lack of focused theoretical articulation. BP as *praxis* must reach out to the human world for models, analogies, exemplars, and norms in order to justify competitive debating practices. This move is the spark that will keep BP valuable as a competition, and also ensure that participants are not practicing tournament moves but moves critical of (and to) human thinking.

Conclusion

Debates are made; debating is a making. Debaters, in cooperation and contest with one another, craft texts orally that are then represented and critiqued in conversation by and with judges. Debate is a productive machine, not a receptive vehicle. Its focus is on creation, crafting, *poesis*, and *inventio*.

I began with Professor Woodward's application of *praxis* in the decision to eliminate judges from his debates one year. I'll end with a panel I attended at the National Communication Association last year, where a panelist understood Howard Woodward to be using the terms "judge" and "audience" as synonyms. This panelist believed that when Woodward advocated judgeless debates, he meant there would be no one watching the debate *at all*. This sort of accidental equivocation of terms is only possible when debating is untheorized. Without *praxis*, scholars from the various debate communities read the norms of their debate experience as the ontological condition of debate throughout time.

Contrasted with this presenter, Woodward was keenly aware of debate's relationship over time to itself, and its contemporary relationship to other forms of debate. Woodward engaged in debate *praxis*. He considered both the aesthetic and mimetic aspects of his judgeless debates. Do these produce good arguments and debates? Are judgeless debates something that go on outside of debate contests? His engagement with both questions can serve as a model for how productive the relationship of debate and *praxis* can be.

In this essay, I have argued that Gadamer's interpretation of *praxis* as the *praktike episteme* is the appropriate grounding for a theory of British Parliamentary debating. In order to maintain the

teleology of debate, BP debate's mimetic and aesthetic qualities should be discussed against a backdrop of daily, lived practices in rhetoric. The differences that arise are pivotal for keeping BP valuable, engaging, and good. Good debating requires a discussion of ends and of purpose, in order to keep debate viable and valuable and to see it as something more than mere competition. I disagree with the idea that the stakes are low in debating. I believe that proper theorization allows us to keep debating in its place, that of a powerful realm to practice the very things that define and maintain the human world. Gadamer's *praxis*, or prudence in human thought, is that necessary maintenance. BP debating is the prudent format of debate.

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